

# Sharpness of Irrationality after One Stabilization for Cubic Threefolds

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## Abstract

The irrationality of  $X \times \mathbf{P}^1$  for every smooth complex cubic threefold  $X$  is sharp: two explicit smooth cubic threefolds over  $\mathbf{Q}$  are rational after multiplication by  $\mathbf{P}^2$ . For each, the least  $m$  such that  $X \times \mathbf{P}^m$  is rational is two over every characteristic-zero ground field. We prove more generally that if  $k$  has characteristic zero,  $S$  is a smooth quartic del Pezzo surface with  $S(k) \neq \emptyset$ , and  $\text{Pic}(S_{\bar{k}})$  is a stably permutation Galois module, then  $S \times \mathbf{A}^2$  is  $k$ -rational. We construct a saturated rank-three subtorus acting on the projective Cox model and prove that the resulting quotient is rational; the residual two-dimensional torus is rational. Applying this theorem to the quartic del Pezzo fibrations of Tschinkel and Zhang, we prove that every member of both cubic series is rational over  $\mathbf{Q}$  after multiplication by  $\mathbf{P}^2$ , showing uniformly that two stabilizing dimensions suffice. Consequently the stabilization level is two on explicit examples in cubic-threefold moduli and infinite at a very general point. We also obtain smooth projective fourfolds  $Y/\mathbf{Q}$  that remain nonrational over  $\mathbf{C}$  but for which  $Y \times \mathbf{A}^1$  is rational over  $\mathbf{Q}$ .

**Keywords.** cubic threefold; quartic del Pezzo surface; stable rationality; universal torsor; variety with one apparent double point; algebraic torus; rationality after affine-line stabilization.

## 1 Introduction and main results

Tschinkel and Zhang constructed explicit stably rational smooth cubic threefolds over  $\mathbf{Q}$  [8, Theorem 1.3]. On the other hand, the one-stabilization theorem shows that every smooth complex cubic threefold remains irrational after multiplication by  $\mathbf{P}^1$  [5, Theorem 1.1]. Thus the stabilization level of the examples of Tschinkel and Zhang is at least two. We prove that this lower bound is attained by two of their examples.

For a geometrically integral variety  $V/k$ , put

$$\ell_k(V) = \min\{m \geq 0 : V \times \mathbf{A}^m \text{ is } k\text{-rational}\}.$$

If the set is empty, put  $\ell_k(V) = \infty$ . Since  $\mathbf{A}^m$  and  $\mathbf{P}^m$  are birational, either factor gives the same invariant. This is the level of stable rationality considered by Tschinkel and Zhang [8, p. 13]. Rationality is preserved by extension of the ground field, so  $\ell_{\mathbf{Q}}(V) \geq \ell_{\mathbf{C}}(V_{\mathbf{C}})$  for  $V/\mathbf{Q}$ .

Consider the smooth cubic threefolds

$$X_1 : (x_4 - 2x_3)x_1^2 + 3(x_4 + 2x_3)x_2^2 + 3x_3^2x_4 - x_4^3 + x_5^3 = 0, \quad (1)$$

$$X_3 : x_4(x_1^2 + 2x_1x_2) + x_3(x_1^2 + x_1x_2 + x_2^2) + x_3^3 - x_3x_4^2 + x_4^3 + 2x_5^3 = 0. \quad (2)$$

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**Theorem 1.1** (Exact level for the cubic threefolds). *For every field  $F$  of characteristic zero and  $j \in \{1, 3\}$ ,*

$$\ell_F((X_j)_F) = 2.$$

*Thus  $(X_j)_F \times \mathbf{P}^1$  is not  $F$ -rational, whereas  $(X_j)_F \times \mathbf{P}^2$  is  $F$ -rational.*

The following surface theorem supplies the upper bound in Theorem 1.1.

Recall that a Galois lattice  $M$  is stably permutation if  $M \oplus P \simeq P'$  for some permutation Galois lattices  $P$  and  $P'$ .

**Theorem 1.2** (Two-dimensional stabilization). *Let  $k$  be a field of characteristic zero and let  $S/k$  be a smooth quartic del Pezzo surface. Suppose that  $S(k) \neq \emptyset$  and that  $\text{Pic}(S_{\bar{k}})$  is a stably permutation  $\text{Gal}(\bar{k}/k)$ -module. Then*

$$S \times \mathbf{A}^2 \quad \text{and, equivalently,} \quad S \times \mathbf{P}^2$$

*are  $k$ -rational. In particular, this holds for every stably  $k$ -rational smooth quartic del Pezzo surface.*

Write  $Z = \text{Proj Cox}(S)$  for the projective Cox model. The new ingredient is a saturated rank-three subtorus  $T_3$  of the rank-five torus acting on  $Z$ , chosen so that  $Z/T_3$  is rational and the residual torus has dimension two. This shows that two stabilizing dimensions suffice.

The use of universal torsors to prove stable rationality goes back to Beauville, Colliot-Thélène, Sansuc, and Swinnerton-Dyer [1]. Tschinkel and Zhang prove the rationality of universal torsors over quartic del Pezzo surfaces and classify the four minimal Galois types relevant to stable rationality. We use their Cox model and its one-apparent-double-point property, Galois classification, and generic splitting of the universal torsor [8]. The tangent-projection theorem for smooth varieties with one apparent double point is due to Ciliberto, Mella, and Russo [2, Corollary 4.2]. Because  $Z$  may be singular, we use the stronger form proved in [8, Theorem 2.4].

When  $S(k) \neq \emptyset$ , the stable-permutation hypothesis is condition (1) of [8, Corollary 4.3]; [8, Proposition 4.1 and Lemma 4.2] identify its equivalent forms, and stable rationality implies it by [4, Theorem 2.2]. The resolution in [8, p. 13] gives a uniform stabilization bound of eleven. We lower this bound to two for all four Galois types. For type  $I_0$ , this bound was already proved by Shepherd-Barron [6]; see also [8, Remark 4.4].

For  $r \geq 0$ , let  $X_{j,r} \subset \mathbf{P}_{\mathbf{Q}}^{r+4}$  be obtained from equation (1) or (2) by adding  $w_1^3 + \cdots + w_r^3$  to its left-hand side. Thus  $X_{j,0} = X_j$ .

**Corollary 1.3** (Two series of cubic hypersurfaces). *For every  $r \geq 0$  and  $j \in \{1, 3\}$ , the variety  $X_{j,r} \times \mathbf{P}^2$  is rational over  $\mathbf{Q}$ .*

Tschinkel and Zhang supply the smoothness, fibrations, and generic-fibre Galois types in [8, Propositions 5.1 and 5.3]. Applying Theorem 1.2 over the two base function fields proves Corollary 1.3 and sharpens their stable-rationality conclusions to  $X_{j,r} \times \mathbf{P}^2$  rational.

**Corollary 1.4** (Rationality after affine-line stabilization). *For  $j \in \{1, 3\}$ , the variety  $Y_j = X_j \times \mathbf{P}^1$  is a smooth projective fourfold over  $\mathbf{Q}$  which remains nonrational over  $\mathbf{C}$ , while  $Y_j \times \mathbf{A}^1$  is rational over  $\mathbf{Q}$ .*

The fourfolds  $Y_j$  answer the question posed in [8, p. 13]: find a nonrational variety  $Y$  such that  $Y \times \mathbf{A}^1$  is rational. This is a birational statement, not Zariski cancellation for isomorphic affine cylinders.

**Corollary 1.5** (Variation in the moduli of cubic threefolds). *On the moduli space of smooth complex cubic threefolds,  $\ell_{\mathbf{C}}((X_j)_{\mathbf{C}}) = 2$  for  $j \in \{1, 3\}$ , whereas  $\ell_{\mathbf{C}}$  is infinite at a very general point.*

Here is the proof of the surface theorem. Let  $Z$  be the projective Cox model of  $S$ . The rank-five torus  $T_0$  acting on  $Z$  contains a saturated rank-three subtorus  $T_3$ . Four of its weight spaces form a Galois-stable set, and their weight differences form a  $\mathbf{Z}$ -basis of the character lattice. A codimension-three tangent section cuts a general  $T_3$ -orbit in one point, so tangent projection identifies  $Z/T_3$  birationally with  $\mathbf{P}^4$ . Generic splitting of the universal torsor also gives  $Z/T_3 \sim_k S \times (T_0/T_3)$ . The residual torus  $T_0/T_3$  has dimension two and is rational; the two descriptions of the quotient therefore give the rationality of  $S \times \mathbf{A}^2$ . Applying the argument over the two base function fields proves Corollary 1.3. In Section 2 we prove the quotient criterion, in Section 3 we construct the required Cox-model section, and in Section 4 we deduce the rationality statements.

## 2 A criterion for rational torus quotients

The criterion below turns a linear section into a rational quotient. Choose  $r + 1$  weight spaces whose weight differences form a basis of the character lattice. Signed maximal minors then give the unique translate of a general torus orbit that lies in a suitable codimension- $r$  linear section. If the section contains the centre of a birational tangent projection, that projection parametrizes the relevant component of the section, and hence the quotient.

The descent hypothesis below is what turns this geometric slice over  $k^s$  into a  $k$ -rational quotient.

Let  $Z \subset \mathbf{P}(V)$  be a geometrically integral  $n$ -fold over an infinite field  $k$ . At a smooth point  $p \in Z(k)$ , write

$$\pi_p : Z \dashrightarrow \mathbf{P}(V/\widehat{T}_p Z) \quad (3)$$

for projection from the embedded tangent space; the hat denotes the affine cone. In the application,  $Z \subset \mathbf{P}^{2n+1}$  has one apparent double point: a general point of  $\mathbf{P}^{2n+1}$  lies on a unique secant line to  $Z$ . Over an algebraically closed field, its tangent projection is birational in the smooth case by [2, Corollary 4.2]. The projective Cox model need not be smooth. The form used here is the stronger [8, Theorem 2.4], which applies to a reduced, irreducible, nondegenerate projective variety whose base change has one apparent double point and whose  $k$ -points are dense. The split Cox model is integral and its homogeneous ideal has no linear equations, so its twists satisfy the additional hypotheses.

**Theorem 2.1** (A quotient criterion). *Let a rank- $r$   $k$ -torus  $T$  act projectively linearly and generically freely on  $Z \subset \mathbf{P}(V)$ , and suppose that the generic tangent projection  $\pi_p$  is birational onto  $\mathbf{P}^n$ . Choose a diagonal linear lift of the action over  $k^s$ . Its weights are determined up to a common translation. Suppose that it has nonzero weight spaces  $V_{w_0}, \dots, V_{w_r}$  such that  $w_1 - w_0, \dots, w_r - w_0$  is a  $\mathbf{Z}$ -basis of  $X^*(T_{k^s})$ . Assume that the sum  $W = V_{w_0} \oplus \dots \oplus V_{w_r}$  and the sum  $\widehat{B}$  of all other weight spaces descend to complementary  $k$ -subspaces of  $V$ ; write  $B = \mathbf{P}(\widehat{B})$ .*

*Suppose that there is a point  $p \in Z(k)$  for which  $\pi_p$  is birational, together with a  $k$ -defined codimension- $r$  linear subspace*

$$\Lambda \supset \langle T_p Z, B \rangle$$

*with equations  $\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_r$ . Suppose there is an open  $U_p \subset Z$  on which  $\pi_p$  is an isomorphism and a geometric point  $x \in (\Lambda \cap U_p)(k^s)$  in the generically free locus such that the matrix*

$$A(x)_{ij} = \lambda_i(x_j), \quad x_j \in V_{w_j}, \quad (4)$$

has rank  $r$  and all  $r+1$  maximal minors nonzero. Then the Rosenlicht quotient  $Z/T$ , whose function field is  $k(Z)^T$ , is  $k$ -rational.

*Proof.* The maximal minors first produce a unique point of  $\Lambda$  on a general  $T$ -orbit. The hypothesis that this section meets  $U_p$  then identifies it birationally with projective space.

For a geometric point  $q = \sum q_j + q_B$ , where  $q_j \in V_{w_j}$  and  $q_B \in \widehat{B}$ , put  $A(q)_{ij} = \lambda_i(q_j)$  and define

$$\kappa_j(q) = (-1)^j \det A(q)_{\widehat{j}}, \quad 0 \leq j \leq r. \quad (5)$$

The equations of  $\Lambda$  vanish on  $B$ , so  $tq \in \Lambda$  is equivalent to

$$A(q)(\chi^{w_0}(t), \dots, \chi^{w_r}(t))^t = 0.$$

The cofactor identity says that the kernel is generated by  $(\kappa_0(q), \dots, \kappa_r(q))$ . The basis hypothesis gives a unique  $t(q) \in T(k^s)$  through

$$\chi^{w_j - w_0}(t(q)) = \frac{\kappa_j(q)}{\kappa_0(q)}, \quad 1 \leq j \leq r. \quad (6)$$

For  $r = 1$ , this says  $\kappa_0 = \lambda_1(q_1)$ ,  $\kappa_1 = -\lambda_1(q_0)$ , and  $\chi^{w_1 - w_0}(t) = \kappa_1/\kappa_0$ : it is the unique scaling that makes  $\lambda_1(tq) = 0$ . Formula (6) is the same cofactor calculation in higher rank. Because the weight differences form a basis, the coordinates of  $t(q)$  are Laurent monomials in the displayed ratios. The construction is unchanged if all weights are translated by one character, since only their differences occur. It is also independent of the ordering of the selected weight spaces: intrinsically,  $s(q) = t(q)q$  is the unique point of  $Tq \cap \Lambda$ . Because  $W$ ,  $\widehat{B}$ , and  $\Lambda$  are defined over  $k$ , Galois conjugation preserves this incidence problem; uniqueness of the intersection point therefore makes  $s$  Galois equivariant. Thus  $s$  is a  $k$ -rational, orbit-invariant retraction on the open where the action is free and the minors do not vanish. Let  $C$  be the closure of its image. Then  $C \dashrightarrow Z/T$  is birational and  $C \subset \Lambda \cap Z$ . Since  $x \in \Lambda$ , the vector  $(1, \dots, 1)$  lies in the kernel of  $A(x)$ ; uniqueness gives  $s(x) = x$ . Thus  $C$  meets  $U_p$ .

The image of  $\Lambda$  under  $\pi_p$  is a linear  $\mathbf{P}^{n-r} \subset \mathbf{P}^n$ , because  $\Lambda$  contains the centre of the linear projection. The irreducible variety  $C$  has dimension  $n - r$ , and  $\pi_p$  is injective on the nonempty open  $C \cap U_p$ . Its image therefore has dimension  $n - r$  and is dense in the linear  $\mathbf{P}^{n-r}$ . Thus

$$\pi_p|_C : C \dashrightarrow \mathbf{P}^{n-r} \quad (7)$$

is dominant and generically injective, hence birational. Therefore  $Z/T$  is  $k$ -rational.

We record the inverse and its domain. Choose linear forms  $\rho_0, \dots, \rho_{n-r}$  whose restrictions give homogeneous coordinates on the image of  $\Lambda$  in  $\mathbf{P}(V/\widehat{T}_p Z)$ . Let  $U \subset Z$  be the invariant open where the action is free, all  $\kappa_j(q)$  are nonzero,  $s(q) \in U_p$ , and  $\rho_0(s(q)) \neq 0$ . These conditions are invariant because  $s$  is orbit invariant and nonvanishing of the signed minors is invariant under the diagonal torus action. Then

$$\Phi : U/T \longrightarrow \mathbf{P}^{n-r}, \quad [q] \longmapsto [\rho_0(s(q)) : \dots : \rho_{n-r}(s(q))] \quad (8)$$

is the quotient parametrization. If  $R_\alpha(x)$  are homogeneous equations for  $Z$ , the graph of its inverse over  $\Phi(U/T)$  is the closure of the locus with  $x \in C \cap U_p$  satisfying

$$\begin{aligned} R_\alpha(x) &= 0 \quad \text{for every } \alpha, \\ \lambda_i(x) &= 0 \quad 1 \leq i \leq r, \\ y_j \rho_0(x) - y_0 \rho_j(x) &= 0 \quad 1 \leq j \leq n - r. \end{aligned} \quad (9)$$

Write its unique point over  $y$  as  $x(y)$  and set  $\Theta(y) = [x(y)]$ . The last line gives  $\Phi(\Theta(y)) = y$ . Conversely,  $s(q) \in \Lambda \cap U_p$  and has the same tangent-projection coordinates as  $x(\Phi([q]))$ ; injectivity of  $\pi_p|_{U_p}$  gives

$$\Theta(\Phi([q])) = [s(q)] = [q] \quad \text{in } U/T.$$

Thus both composites are the identity on the stated dense opens. In the Cox application, the  $R_\alpha$  in (9) are the twenty quadrics in [8, Section 3]. Equations (6) and (9) give the rational map and its inverse without an unrecorded finite cover.  $\square$

The integral-basis condition is essential. If the weight differences span a proper finite-index sublattice, the same equations generally define a finite cover of a  $T$ -orbit rather than a rational section.

The proof is constructive once equations for  $Z$ , a tangent point, and the linear forms  $\lambda_i$  are given. The signed minors in (5) compute the orbit correction, and (9) recovers the inverse parametrization by elimination. Thus such a tangent section produces explicit rational maps in either direction. No estimate for the complexity of that elimination is asserted.

### 3 The rank-three subtorus of the projective Cox model

This section verifies the hypotheses of Theorem 2.1 for the projective Cox model. Four facts from Tschinkel and Zhang enter. The model is seven-dimensional, tangent projection from a general point is birational, and the scalar quotient of its rank-six Néron–Severi torus has rank five. In the minimal case, the stable-permutation hypothesis restricts the Galois image to four conjugacy types  $I_0, \dots, I_3$  in  $W(D_5)$ . A rational point on the surface gives Zariski-dense rational points on the model and a generic splitting of the universal torsor. We construct the rank-three subtorus and tangent section for  $I_3$ ; subgroup containment gives the other types after a change of marking.

Let  $T$  be the Néron–Severi torus, so  $X^*(T_{\bar{k}}) = \text{Pic}(S_{\bar{k}})$ . The Galois-invariant cocharacter

$$\lambda_{-K} : \mathbf{G}_m \longrightarrow T, \quad D \longmapsto (-K_S, D), \quad (10)$$

acts by simultaneous scalar multiplication on the sixteen Cox generators. Write  $T_0 = T/\lambda_{-K}(\mathbf{G}_m)$ , a torus of rank five. Over  $\bar{k}$ , the projective Cox model

$$Z = \text{Proj Cox}(S) \subset \mathbf{P}^{15}$$

is a seven-dimensional variety with one apparent double point [8, Lemma 3.2].

In the marking of [8, Sections 3–4],  $E_i$ ,  $L_{ij}$ , and  $Q$  are the Cox generators for an exceptional curve, the line through two blowup points, and the conic through all five points, respectively. For the type  $I_3$  Galois image, the sublattice

$$N_3 = \mathbf{Z}e_3 \oplus \mathbf{Z}e_4 \oplus \mathbf{Z}e_5 \subset X_*(T_{0,\bar{k}}) \quad (11)$$

is saturated and Galois stable. The two displayed generators of the type- $I_3$  Galois image act on this basis by

$$\begin{bmatrix} -1 & 0 & 0 \\ -1 & 0 & 1 \\ -1 & 1 & 0 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Let  $T_3 \subset T_0$  be the corresponding rank-three subtorus.

*Remark 3.1* (Saturation and the projective kernel). In the type- $I_1$  description, the three visible sign cocharacters in the last three coordinates are

$$(0, 1, 1), \quad (1, 0, 1), \quad (1, 1, 0).$$

They span the even-sum sublattice of  $\mathbf{Z}^3$ , of index two. Its saturation is  $\mathbf{Z}^3$ , obtained by adjoining

$$(1, 1, 1) = \frac{1}{2}((0, 1, 1) + (1, 0, 1) + (1, 1, 0)).$$

The map from the three parameter copies of  $\mathbf{G}_m$  to their image in the projective torus has kernel  $\mu_2$ . The degree two obtained from the unsaturated parameters counts this kernel; it is not the degree of the Rosenlicht quotient. Saturation gives the integral-basis condition in Theorem 2.1.

We seek four projective weight spaces whose pairwise weight differences generate the full rank-three character lattice and whose complement is Galois stable. These conditions supply, respectively, the unique orbit correction and the descent required by Theorem 2.1. The following four groups of Cox generators span such weight spaces:

| weight      | Cox generators           |
|-------------|--------------------------|
| $(0, 1, 1)$ | $L_{13}, L_{23}, L_{35}$ |
| $(1, 0, 1)$ | $L_{14}, L_{24}, L_{45}$ |
| $(1, 1, 0)$ | $E_1, E_2, E_5$          |
| $(1, 1, 1)$ | $L_{12}, L_{15}, L_{25}$ |

These four weight spaces form a Galois-stable set, but they are not individually Galois stable. On their weights, the first displayed generator acts by

$$(011 \ 111)(101 \ 110),$$

and the second by  $(110 \ 111)$ , fixing 011 and 101. These are affine actions on projective weights: a different diagonal lift translates all four weights by a common character. Every other Cox generator lies in the Galois-stable subspace

$$B = \mathbf{P}\langle E_3, E_4, L_{34}, Q \rangle. \tag{12}$$

The determinant of the three weight differences from  $(0, 1, 1)$  is one. Consequently the direct sum of the four selected weight spaces and the affine cone over  $B$  are complementary subspaces defined over the ground field, as required in Theorem 2.1. On the open where the four selected weight-space components are nonzero, a projective stabilizer fixes their three ratios. The three weight differences form a basis, so that stabilizer is trivial. In particular, the  $T_3$ -action is generically free.

**Proposition 3.2** (A tangent section for the four Galois types). *Let  $k$  be a field of characteristic zero, let  $S/k$  be a smooth quartic del Pezzo surface, and let  $Z$  be its projective Cox model. Over  $\bar{k}$  there exist a general tangent point  $p$ , a point  $x$ , and a codimension-three linear subspace  $\Lambda \supset \langle T_p Z, B \rangle$  such that  $x \in \Lambda \cap U_p$  and the maximal-minor condition of Theorem 2.1 holds at  $x$  for  $T_3$ . If  $S(k) \neq \emptyset$  and the Galois image has type  $I_0, I_1, I_2$ , or  $I_3$ , such a triple  $(p, x, \Lambda)$  exists over  $k$ .*

*Proof.* For  $p \in Z_{\text{sm}}$ , let  $H_p$  be the space of tangent hyperplanes containing  $B$ . If  $x = \sum_{j=0}^3 x_j + x_B$  is its weight-space decomposition, evaluation gives

$$\text{ev}_{p,x} : H_p \longrightarrow k^4, \quad \lambda \longmapsto (\lambda(x_0), \dots, \lambda(x_3)).$$

Let  $\mathcal{E}_{\text{ev}} \subset Z_{\text{sm}} \times Z$  be the open locus where  $H_p$  has dimension four,  $\text{ev}_{p,x}$  is an isomorphism, and the  $T_3$ -action is free at  $x$ . These are the open conditions needed to construct the codimension-three orbit slice.

We impose the tangent-projection condition uniformly in  $p$ . Let  $G \subset Z_{\text{sm}}$  be the nonempty open over which the tangent projection is birational. The affine tangent spaces form a subbundle  $\widehat{\mathcal{T}} \subset V \otimes \mathcal{O}_G$ . Put

$$\mathcal{Q} = (V \otimes \mathcal{O}_G) / \widehat{\mathcal{T}}.$$

The tangent projections are the fibres of the rational  $G$ -map

$$\Pi : G \times Z \dashrightarrow \mathbf{P}_G(\mathcal{Q}), \quad (p, x) \longmapsto (p, \pi_p(x)).$$

The induced map on the generic fibre of  $G$  is birational, so  $\Pi$  restricts to an isomorphism between dense open subsets of its source and target. Denote the source open by  $\mathcal{U}$ . Thus  $(p, x) \in \mathcal{U}$  is a single open condition on the pair, and its fibre over  $p$  is an open  $U_p$  on which  $\pi_p$  is an isomorphism.

It remains to show that  $\mathcal{E}_{\text{ev}}$  is nonempty for every split Cox model attached to a smooth quartic del Pezzo surface. Use the standard blowup points

$$(1 : 0 : 0), (0 : 1 : 0), (0 : 0 : 1), (1 : 1 : 1), (1 : a : b), \quad \Delta = ab(a-1)(b-1)(a-b) \neq 0. \quad (13)$$

Appendix A records four exact split-coordinate witnesses and proves that their evaluation-and-smoothness opens cover  $\{\Delta \neq 0\}$ , as stated in (18). Hence  $\mathcal{E}_{\text{ev}}$  is nonempty. Since  $G \times Z$  is geometrically integral, the intersection  $\mathcal{U} \cap (\mathcal{E}_{\text{ev}}|_{G \times Z})$  is nonempty.

Choose  $(p, x)$  in this intersection. Then  $p$  is general for tangent projection,  $x \in U_p$ , the evaluation map is an isomorphism at  $x$ , and the  $T_3$ -action is free at  $x$ .

The inverse image under  $\text{ev}_{p,x}$  of the hyperplane  $u_0 + u_1 + u_2 + u_3 = 0$  is the three-dimensional space of elements of  $H_p$  that vanish at  $x$ . Choose a basis  $\lambda_1, \lambda_2, \lambda_3$  and let  $\Lambda$  be their common zero locus. Then  $x \in \Lambda \cap U_p$ , and the four maximal minors of the three evaluation rows are all nonzero. Thus the same point  $x$  satisfies both the minor condition and the tangent-projection condition.

It remains to obtain  $p$ ,  $x$ , and  $\Lambda$  over the ground field. Fix a  $k$ -form whose Galois image has one of the four types. Because  $T_3$ ,  $B$ , the set of four selected weight spaces, and the universal tangent-projection map are defined over  $k$ , the intersection  $\mathcal{U} \cap (\mathcal{E}_{\text{ev}}|_{G \times Z})$  is a nonempty  $k$ -open in  $G \times Z$ . Its projection to  $G$  is dense constructible and therefore contains a nonempty open  $G_0$ .

Corollary 3.5 of [8] supplies the universal torsor whose fibre over a fixed point of  $S(k)$  is trivial. Its  $k$ -points are Zariski dense by [8, Lemma 2.1], and the same holds in the projective Cox model. Hence  $G_0$  contains a point  $p \in Z(k)$ . The fibre  $(\mathcal{U} \cap (\mathcal{E}_{\text{ev}}|_{G \times Z}))_p$  is a nonempty  $k$ -open in  $Z$ , so Zariski density supplies a point  $x \in Z(k)$  in that fibre. The functional  $H_p \rightarrow k$ ,  $\lambda \mapsto \lambda(x)$ , has a three-dimensional kernel, so a  $k$ -basis gives  $\Lambda$ . We do not claim that any one of the four displayed coordinate choices descends.

For type  $I_3$ , stability of  $N_3$ ,  $B$ , and the set of four selected Cox weight spaces is checked on the two displayed generators. Up to conjugacy in  $W(D_5)$ , the groups of types  $I_0, I_1, I_2$  are subgroups of the group of type  $I_3$  [8, Lemma 4.2]. Restriction and a change of marking preserve the same data. The stable-permutation hypothesis implies that  $H^1(H, \text{Pic}(S_k)) = 0$  for every subgroup  $H$  of the Galois image. In the minimal quartic del Pezzo case, Tschinkel and Zhang show that this leaves exactly the four types  $I_0, \dots, I_3$  [8, Proposition 4.1 and Lemma 4.2]. This is not a classification of arbitrary subgroups of  $W(D_5)$ .  $\square$

## 4 Proofs of the rationality statements

*Proof of Theorem 1.2.* We first treat the minimal case by taking a quotient of the projective Cox model. An equivariant generic trivialization then identifies that quotient with the product of  $S$  and a two-dimensional torus. The nonminimal case reduces to the classical rationality theorem in degree at least five.

Suppose first that  $S$  is  $k$ -minimal. Since a stably permutation module has vanishing  $H^1$  on every open subgroup, Proposition 4.1 and Lemma 4.2 of [8] place the Galois image in one of the four types used in Proposition 3.2. Lemma 3.2 and Theorem 2.4 of [8], together with Theorem 2.1, give

$$Z/T_3 \sim_k \mathbf{P}^4. \quad (14)$$

By [8, Corollary 3.5], let  $\mathcal{T} \rightarrow S$  be a universal torsor under the Néron–Severi torus  $T$ , chosen to have a  $k$ -point above a fixed point of  $S(k)$ . The stable-permutation identity for  $X^*(T_k)$  implies that  $T \times Q \simeq Q'$  for suitable quasi-trivial tori  $Q, Q'$ ; here quasi-trivial means that the character lattice is a permutation Galois module. Hilbert’s Theorem 90 therefore gives

$$H^1(F, T) = 0 \quad \text{for every field extension } F/k \quad (15)$$

by [8, Remark 2.2]. Thus the generic fibre over  $k(S)$  has a point. Equivalently, the torsor has a rational section  $\sigma$ . Translation by  $\sigma$  defines the  $T$ -equivariant birational map

$$S \times T \dashrightarrow \mathcal{T}, \quad (s, t) \mapsto \sigma(s)t. \quad (16)$$

The split scalar subtorus in (10) acts as common multiplication on every Cox coordinate. The universal torsor is a dense open in the affine Cox cone, and its scalar quotient is a dense open in  $Z$ . Quotienting (16) by that scalar therefore gives a  $T_0$ -equivariant birational map  $S \times T_0 \dashrightarrow Z$ . Since  $T_3 \subset T_0$  is a  $k$ -subtorus, Rosenlicht quotients give

$$Z/T_3 \sim_k S \times (T_0/T_3). \quad (17)$$

The quotient  $T_0/T_3$  is a two-dimensional  $k$ -torus, hence is  $k$ -rational by [10]. Equations (14) and (17) prove that  $S \times \mathbf{A}^2$  is  $k$ -rational.

If  $S$  is not  $k$ -minimal, successively contracting  $k$ -defined unions of pairwise disjoint exceptional curves gives a del Pezzo surface  $S'$  of degree at least five. The image of a  $k$ -point of  $S$  is a  $k$ -point of  $S'$ , so  $S'$ , and therefore  $S$ , is  $k$ -rational by [9, Theorem 2.1].

Finally, if  $S$  is stably  $k$ -rational, a nonempty open of a projective space is birational to a nonempty open of  $S \times \mathbf{P}^m$ . Since  $k$  is infinite, this supplies a  $k$ -point on  $S$ . Manin’s stable birational Picard-module obstruction implies that  $\text{Pic}(S_k)$  is stably permutation. In the form used here, this consequence of [4, Theorem 2.2] is recalled immediately before [8, Proposition 4.1] and included in [8, Corollary 4.3]. This proves the last assertion.  $\square$

*Proof of Corollary 1.3.* The argument takes place entirely over the function field of the projection base. This avoids any specialization or fibrewise rationality claim.

For  $X = X_{j,r}$ , Tschinkel and Zhang project from a plane containing a distinguished line. The base is  $\mathbf{P}_{\mathbf{Q}}^{r+1}$ , with function field  $K = \mathbf{Q}(t_1, \dots, t_{r+1})$ , and the generic cubic-surface fibre is  $K$ -birational, after contracting the distinguished line, to a smooth quartic del Pezzo surface  $S/K$  with a  $K$ -point. Their calculation identifies the Galois image as type  $I_1$  for  $j = 1$  and type  $I_3$  for  $j = 3$  [8, Propositions 5.1 and 5.3]. Lemma 4.2 of [8] then shows that  $\text{Pic}(S_K)$  is stably permutation. Theorem 1.2 gives

$$K(S)(u, v) \simeq K(z_1, z_2, z_3, z_4).$$



Since  $\mathbf{Q}(X) = K(S)$  as extensions of  $K$ ,

$$\mathbf{Q}(X)(u, v) \simeq \mathbf{Q}(t_1, \dots, t_{r+1}, z_1, z_2, z_3, z_4)$$

is purely transcendental. This is rationality of  $X \times \mathbf{A}^2$ , equivalently of  $X \times \mathbf{P}^2$ . This is a function-field argument; no specialization assertion is used.  $\square$

*Proof of Theorem 1.1.* The one-stabilization theorem proves that  $X \times \mathbf{P}^1$  is irrational for every smooth complex cubic threefold  $X$  [5, Theorem 1.1]. It applies to  $(X_j)_{\mathbf{C}}$ . Therefore  $(X_j)_{\mathbf{C}}$  has no rational stabilization with  $m \leq 1$ . Suppose one existed over a characteristic-zero field  $F$ . A birational map to projective space, its inverse, and their composition identities use only finitely many coefficients. They therefore descend together to a finitely generated subfield  $F_0/\mathbf{Q}$  of  $F$ , including the nonzero denominators defining their domains. An embedding  $F_0 \hookrightarrow \mathbf{C}$  would give the forbidden rationalization over  $\mathbf{C}$ . No embedding of all of  $F$  is needed. Corollary 1.3 gives rationality at  $m = 2$  over  $\mathbf{Q}$ , which base-changes to  $F$ . Hence the level is exactly two.  $\square$

*Proof of Corollary 1.4.* Theorem 1.1 shows that  $Y_j = X_j \times \mathbf{P}^1$  is nonrational, even after base change to  $\mathbf{C}$ . On the other hand,

$$\mathbf{Q}(Y_j \times \mathbf{A}^1) = \mathbf{Q}(X_j)(u, t)$$

is purely transcendental by Corollary 1.3. Equivalently,  $\mathbf{P}^1 \times \mathbf{A}^1$  is birational to  $\mathbf{A}^2$ . Hence  $Y_j \times \mathbf{A}^1$  is rational.  $\square$

*Proof of Corollary 1.5.* Theorem 1.1 gives the asserted value for  $X_1$  and  $X_3$ . Engel, de Gaay Fortman, and Schreieder prove that a very general smooth complex cubic threefold does not admit a decomposition of the diagonal and hence is not stably rational [3, Corollary 1.4]. For such a threefold no finite  $m$  makes  $X \times \mathbf{P}^m$  rational, so  $\ell_{\mathbf{C}}(X) = \infty$ .  $\square$

## 5 Generic surfaces, partners, and fibrations

The same function-field argument shows that the surface bound itself is sharp. Let  $S_j/\mathbf{Q}(t)$  be the generic quartic del Pezzo surface obtained from  $X_j$  in the proof of Corollary 1.3.

**Corollary 5.1** (Exact level of the generic surfaces). *For every field  $F$  of characteristic zero and  $j \in \{1, 3\}$ ,*

$$\ell_{F(t)}((S_j)_{F(t)}) = 2.$$

*Proof.* The rationalization of  $S_j \times \mathbf{A}^2$  over  $\mathbf{Q}(t)$  constructed in the proof of Corollary 1.3 base-changes to  $F(t)$ . The same generic-fibre identification gives  $F(X_j) = F(t)((S_j)_{F(t)})$ . If the surface were rational after one stabilization, then

$$F(X_j)(u) \simeq F(t)(z_1, z_2, z_3)$$

would be purely transcendental over  $F$ , contradicting Theorem 1.1. Rationality without stabilization would also imply rationality after one stabilization. This proves the lower bound. The argument does not require the Galois image to retain its original type after extension of the ground field.  $\square$

Exact level also transfers through the projective-line correspondences used in the companion paper.

**Corollary 5.2** (Partners of the specified cubics). *Let  $F$  have characteristic zero and let  $V/F$  be a geometrically integral threefold. If, for some  $j \in \{1, 3\}$ ,*

$$V \times \mathbf{P}^1 \sim_F (X_j)_F \times \mathbf{P}^1,$$

*then  $\ell_F(V) = 2$ .*

*Proof.* The displayed product is irrational by Theorem 1.1. Taking one further product with  $\mathbf{P}^1$ , and using  $\mathbf{P}^1 \times \mathbf{P}^1 \sim_F \mathbf{P}^2$ , gives

$$V \times \mathbf{P}^2 \sim_F (X_j)_F \times \mathbf{P}^2 \sim_F \mathbf{P}^5.$$

Thus two stabilizations suffice and one does not.  $\square$

*Remark 5.3* (Genus-eight Fano partners). Over an algebraically closed field of characteristic zero, Kuznetsov's flop relates rank-two projective bundles over a smooth genus-eight Fano threefold and its associated Pfaffian cubic [7, Theorems 2.17–2.18]. A projective bundle is birational to the product with projective space. Hence Corollary 5.2 applies when the associated cubic is  $(X_1)_F$  or  $(X_3)_F$ . Over other fields the same conclusion holds whenever that correspondence is defined over  $F$ . It is not an exact-level statement for arbitrary genus-eight Fano threefolds.

For a general fibration the base contributes its own stabilization level. The following formula keeps track of the four free variables supplied by the surface rationalization.

**Proposition 5.4** (Stabilization along a surface fibration). *Let  $k$  have characteristic zero, and let  $Y \dashrightarrow B$  be a dominant rational map of geometrically integral  $k$ -varieties. Suppose its generic fibre is  $k(B)$ -birational to a smooth quartic del Pezzo surface satisfying the hypotheses of Theorem 1.2. Then*

$$Y \times \mathbf{A}^2 \sim_k B \times \mathbf{A}^4, \quad \max\{\ell_k(Y) - 2, 0\} = \max\{\ell_k(B) - 4, 0\},$$

*where subtracting a finite integer from  $\infty$  leaves  $\infty$ . In particular,  $\ell_k(B) \leq 4$  implies  $\ell_k(Y) \leq 2$ ; if  $4 < \ell_k(B) < \infty$ , then  $\ell_k(Y) = \ell_k(B) - 2$ . The variety  $Y$  is stably rational if and only if  $B$  is.*

*Proof.* Put  $K = k(B)$ . The surface theorem gives

$$k(Y)(u, v) \simeq K(z_1, z_2, z_3, z_4),$$

which proves the birational equivalence over  $k$ . For every geometrically integral variety  $W$  and integer  $a \geq 0$ , the definition of the level gives

$$\ell_k(W \times \mathbf{A}^a) = \max\{\ell_k(W) - a, 0\}.$$

Indeed, further stabilization by  $m$  makes this product rational exactly when stabilization of  $W$  by  $a + m$  does; rationality persists under additional affine factors. This also proves the formula when the level is infinite. Apply it to the two birational varieties above. The stated consequences follow by considering whether  $\ell_k(B)$  is at most four, finite and greater than four, or infinite.  $\square$

## 6 A limitation of the rank-four construction

The rank-three construction uses four weight spaces, each of dimension three. Their multiplicities are essential to descent. For the full type- $I_3$  Galois image, increasing the rank separates these weights and prevents the same quotient criterion from applying.

**Proposition 6.1** (Rank-four subtori and descent). *Suppose that the Galois image on the marked projective Cox model is the full group  $I_3$ . The torus  $T_0$  has a unique rank-four  $k$ -subtorus  $T_4$ . Its sixteen Cox-coordinate weights are distinct and have Galois orbits of sizes four and twelve. Consequently no set of five of its weight spaces has a direct sum defined over  $k$ , and  $T_4$  cannot satisfy the weight-space descent hypothesis of Theorem 2.1.*

*Proof.* Write  $M = X^*(T_{0,\bar{k}})$ , using the basis dual to the cocharacter basis in (11). A rank-four subtorus corresponds to a saturated, Galois-stable rank-one kernel in  $M$ . Each of the two character generators  $A, B$  of  $I_3$  must act on such a kernel by a sign. The stacked matrices

$$\begin{pmatrix} A - \varepsilon I \\ B - \eta I \end{pmatrix}, \quad (\varepsilon, \eta) = (-1, -1), (-1, 1), (1, -1), (1, 1),$$

have ranks  $(5, 4, 5, 5)$ , respectively. The sole rational line is generated by

$$m = (-1, -1, -3, -3, 3), \quad Am = -m, \quad Bm = m.$$

Its first coordinate is a unit, so  $m$  is primitive and the integral kernel is  $\mathbf{Z}m$ . This proves existence and uniqueness of  $T_4$ .

Restriction of weights is the quotient  $M \rightarrow M/\mathbf{Z}m$ . In the basis given by the last four standard basis classes, it is

$$(w_1, w_2, w_3, w_4, w_5) \mapsto (w_2 - w_1, w_3 - 3w_1, w_4 - 3w_1, w_5 + 3w_1).$$

The sixteen restricted weights are distinct. Recovering the affine Galois actions, including the common translations of projective weights, gives the orbit

$$\{E_3, E_4, L_{34}, Q\}$$

and its twelve-element complement. The exact calculation of these ranks, weights and permutations is recorded in the rank-four certificate. Since every weight space is one-dimensional, a sum of five weight spaces could descend only if its five weights formed a Galois-stable set. A union of the two orbits has size 0, 4, 12, or 16, never five.  $\square$

This failure concerns descent, rather than the integral basis condition. Among all 4,368 five-subsets of the sixteen weights, exactly 1,992 have four differences forming a basis of  $M/\mathbf{Z}m$ . None is Galois stable. On restriction to  $T_3$ , the twelve-element orbit instead forms the four three-dimensional weight spaces used above. The same orbit argument excludes rank five: the full  $T_0$  weights are already distinct and have the same two orbits, whereas the criterion would require six weight spaces with descended direct sum. Thus rank three is the largest possible rank for this criterion in the full- $I_3$  Cox representation. The proposition applies to this Cox embedding and the full  $I_3$  action; it makes no assertion about other embeddings, nonlinear sections, or smaller Galois images.

## A Exact tangent-section certificate

For a tangent point  $p$  parametrized by  $z = (z_1, z_2, z_3)$ , the space  $H_p$  of tangent hyperplanes containing  $B$  has dimension four. Evaluation on the four selected weight spaces gives a 4-by-4 matrix. The following table records four exact witnesses. In each row,  $z$  specifies  $p$ ,  $e = (e_1, \dots, e_5)$  gives the five coordinates  $E_1, \dots, E_5$  of  $x$ , and the remaining coordinates  $L_{ij}$  and  $Q$  are reconstructed from  $e, z'$  and satisfy all twenty Cox quadrics. The individual values serve only to certify nonemptiness of the required open.

| $i$ | $z$        | $e$                | $z'$        |
|-----|------------|--------------------|-------------|
| 1   | (1, 3, 7)  | (2, 3, 5, 7, 11)   | (2, 4, 9)   |
| 2   | (2, 5, 11) | (3, 4, 7, 13, 17)  | (1, 6, 10)  |
| 3   | (3, 8, 13) | (5, 7, 11, 17, 19) | (2, 9, 15)  |
| 4   | (4, 9, 17) | (2, 5, 11, 19, 23) | (3, 10, 18) |

Let  $D_i$  be the determinant of the evaluation matrix for choice  $i$ , and let  $M_i$  be the fixed 8-by-8 Jacobian minor at the same tangent point. Choice  $i$  certifies the evaluation and smoothness conditions on the open  $D_i M_i \neq 0$ . After discarding nonzero rational factors, the four evaluation determinants are

$$\begin{aligned}
D_1 &= (8a - 27)^2 (3968a - 1349b - 2619), \\
D_2 &= 568453977a^3 - 373279764a^2b - 1658788404a^2 \\
&\quad + 59068867ab^2 + 976763788ab + 925668016a \\
&\quad - 128537024b^2 - 359163728b - 10185728, \\
D_3 &= 1643918400a^3 - 1105797420a^2b - 7261914240a^2 \\
&\quad + 154718524ab^2 + 3804690316ab + 9944961600a \\
&\quad - 282623593b^2 - 3443769343b - 3454184244, \\
D_4 &= 35068545a^3 + 2864538a^2b - 236376549a^2 \\
&\quad - 5350827ab^2 + 24417420ab + 469658574a \\
&\quad + 14536855b^2 - 90750394b - 214068162.
\end{aligned}$$

and the corresponding smoothness minors are

$$\begin{aligned}
M_1 &= -4(a-1)(b-7)(3a-b-2)(2ab+7a-9b), \\
M_2 &= -9(a-1)(2b-11)(3a-b-2)(4ab+11a-15b), \\
M_3 &= -25(a-1)(3b-13)(2a-b-1)(3ab+13a-16b), \\
M_4 &= -(a-1)(4b-17)(13a-5b-8)(32ab+85a-117b).
\end{aligned}$$

The assertion used in Proposition 3.2 is

$$\{\Delta \neq 0\} \subseteq \bigcup_{i=1}^4 \{D_i M_i \neq 0\}. \quad (18)$$

The opens  $D_i M_i \neq 0$  are not contained in  $\{\Delta \neq 0\}$ ; only the containment is claimed.

To prove (18), suppose first that  $D_i M_i = 0$  for  $i = 1, 2, 3$ . Choosing one factor from each product gives eight cases. A lexicographic Gröbner calculation in  $\mathbf{Q}[a, b, h]/(h\Delta - 1)$  gives

| chosen equations                                     | localized zero locus                  |
|------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| $D_1 D_2 D_3, D_1 D_2 M_3, D_1 M_2 D_3, D_1 M_2 M_3$ | empty                                 |
| $M_1 D_2 D_3, M_1 D_2 M_3$                           | empty                                 |
| $M_1 M_2 D_3$                                        | $3a - b - 2 = Q_0(b) = 0$             |
| $M_1 M_2 M_3$                                        | $3a - b - 2 = (3b - 26)(3b - 13) = 0$ |

where

$$Q_0(b) = 31223016b^2 - 435944529b + 1306078948.$$

On the line  $3a - b - 2 = 0$ , the primitive numerator of  $D_4 M_4$  is

$$-(b-1)^4(4b-17)(16b-85)(83246b^2 - 872181b + 2185995),$$

$$Q_4(b) = 83246b^2 - 872181b + 2185995.$$

The evaluations

$$Q_0(17/4) = \frac{69121705}{4}, \quad Q_0(85/16) = -\frac{4117757269}{32},$$

$$Q_4(26/3) = \frac{7918133}{9}, \quad Q_4(13/3) = -\frac{272530}{9}$$

exclude the four linear roots. Finally, the two quadratics are coprime by the identity

$$(2265746679974131615 - 377042650728395274b)Q_0(b) \\ + (141417109727495582904b - 1342668830289072756147)Q_4(b) \\ = 24176690547344887359179755.$$

Thus  $D_4 M_4 \neq 0$  in both remaining cases. This proves that the four opens  $D_i M_i \neq 0$  cover  $\Delta \neq 0$ . The retained certificate gives, for each empty case, an identity expressing a nonzero constant in the corresponding localized ideal.

## B Verification and scope

Using exact integer and rational arithmetic, the reconstruction program starts from the two type- $I_3$  character matrices and the twenty Cox quadrics in [8, Section 3]. With SymPy 1.14.0, it reconstructs the saturated rank-three lattice, residual rank-two torus, Cox weights, tangent Jacobian, four pairs  $(D_i, M_i)$ , eight localized cases, and Bézout identity. It also verifies the weight basis, derives the linear section from the kernel of  $H_p \rightarrow k$ ,  $\lambda \mapsto \lambda(x)$ , and renders every computation-derived value printed in the manuscript into a generated TeX file checked by the verification gate. The certificate retains exact Nullstellensatz identities for the six empty cases, which both verification programs verify directly; the second program also checks the cover, linear section, and quotient minors. The source transcription, quotient criterion, equivariant generic trivialization, descent of the tangent-section conditions, and function-field argument are checked in the text, not by the programs.

For Proposition 6.1, a separate certificate exhausts the four sign systems and all five-subsets of the sixteen weights. One program computes determinants in the rank-four quotient; an independent program computes the corresponding rank-five determinants in  $M$ , using integer arithmetic without SymPy. It also checks the affine actions and the rank-three weight multiplicities. Negative controls detect an unsaturated character generator and omission of the affine translations.

No Lean development formalizes Theorem 1.1, Theorem 1.2, Theorem 2.1, Proposition 3.2, or the stated corollaries. The formal-coverage annotations therefore say **absent**.

We import Tschinkel–Zhang’s universal-torsor geometry and their classification of the four Galois images for which  $H^1$  vanishes on every subgroup. We construct the rational quotient by a rank-three subtorus and its descended tangent section. This construction lowers the stabilization bound to two; no classification beyond those four Galois types is needed here.

## AI assistance disclosure

This project was developed with extensive assistance from OpenAI Codex and Anthropic Claude. Under the author’s direction, the systems assisted with proof exploration, literature research, exact computation, verification, and manuscript drafting and revision. The author checked the resulting arguments, computations, code, and cited sources, reviewed and edited all AI-assisted material, and assumes responsibility for all content.

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